Digital Pathshala
by Aaryaman · AI + digital skills for work

FREE EBOOK · 2026

BANK STATEMENTS · PRICE LISTS · PORTAL REPORTS

PDF tables into Excel — the honest, verified guide

Which method works for which PDF, the exact Excel steps, how to check the totals, what never works, and what to think about before you upload a bank statement to any AI.

25.47 bn
UPI transactions in India in October 2026 — about 822 million a day

0 rows
what Excel's PDF import gives you from a scanned PDF

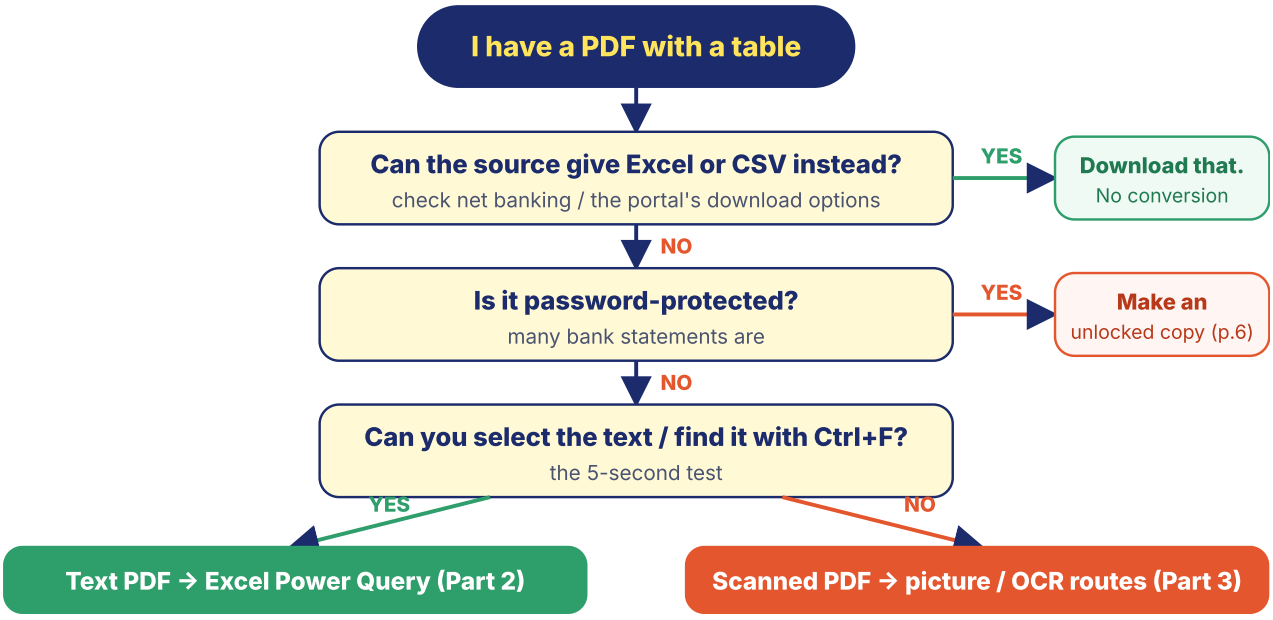
100 pages
the most Claude can read visually in one PDF; beyond that, text only

Every claim on these pages is checked against Microsoft, Anthropic and Government of India sources

youtube.com/@DigitalPathshalabyAaryaman

Start here: what kind of PDF do you have?

No single method works for every PDF. Choosing the wrong one is why most "PDF to Excel" attempts fail. Answer three questions first.



The 5-second test

TEXT PDF (DIGITAL)

You can drag to select words, and `Ctrl` + `F` finds them. This is usually what net banking and portals generate. **Excel's PDF import can read it.**

IMAGE PDF (SCANNED OR PHOTOGRAPHED)

Nothing selects, and Ctrl+F finds nothing. Excel's PDF import returns **empty results**, because it reads only PDFs that contain real text.

Source: Microsoft Q&A, accepted answer by a Microsoft moderator, 25 Feb 2026 ("Pdf.Tables extracts tables only from native PDFs that contain selectable text... If you can't select or search anything, the PDF is image-based").

Why this is getting harder: UPI handled **25.47 billion** transactions in October 2026, about **822 million a day**, up 23% from a year earlier (NPCI data, via Free Press Journal, 2 Nov 2026). More small payments mean more lines, and more pages, in every account statement.

1 Excel's built-in PDF import: what it is

Power Query's "From PDF" — free inside Excel, if you have the right version.

Excel has a data tool called **Power Query** (Data tab → Get & Transform). One of its sources is **From PDF**. It finds the tables in a PDF, lets you clean them, and remembers every step so you can repeat it.

Question	Verified answer
Which Excel?	Excel for Microsoft 365 and Excel 2024 **for Windows**.
Excel for Mac?	**No.** Microsoft MVPs on Microsoft Q&A (Feb 2025) confirmed there is no Get Data from PDF on Mac; the workaround is copy-paste or Data from Picture.
Password-protected PDFs?	**Not supported.** Make an unlocked copy first (page 6).
Scanned PDFs?	**No** — it needs selectable text. Use Part 3.
Tables over several pages?	Yes. By default it combines similar tables on consecutive pages (option `MultiPageTables`, default true).
Very large PDFs?	Microsoft suggests reading pages in ranges (`StartPage` / `EndPage`) to avoid slowdowns and timeouts.
Multi-line rows?	Not always detected correctly. Microsoft suggests fixing them with Fill Down or Group By (page 5).
Do I upload the file anywhere?	No. In Excel on Windows you browse to the file on your own computer.

Sources: Microsoft Learn, "PDF connector" and "Pdf.Tables"; Office Watch, "How to import PDFs into Excel and auto-refresh data using Power Query", 24 Jan 2026; Microsoft Q&A threads 5396350 (Feb 2025) and 5788673 (Feb 2026).

CORRECTION TO OUR EARLIER TOPIC LIST

We earlier wrote that Power Query handles bank statements in general. It doesn't: it fails on scanned and password-protected PDFs, and every bank's layout needs its own clean-up steps. This ebook replaces that claim.

2 Import a PDF table, step by step

Excel for Microsoft 365 or 2024, on Windows.



1. Open a blank workbook. Go to `Data → Get Data → From File → From PDF`.
2. Browse to the PDF on your computer and click **Import**.
3. The **Navigator** lists every table and page Excel found. Click each one to preview it. Tick **Select multiple items** if the table runs across pages.
4. Click **Transform Data** (not Load), so you can clean it in the Power Query Editor.
5. Clean it (next page), then click **Close & Load**. The data lands in a new sheet as a table.

If the transactions are split into many small tables

1. Load each table as a query (Navigator → select multiple items → Transform Data).
2. In the editor, use `Home → Append Queries → Append Queries as New` and add all the pieces.
3. Do the clean-up once, on the appended query.

Advanced: control pages and table detection

In `Home → Advanced Editor` the source step uses `Pdf.Tables`. Microsoft documents these options:

```
Pdf.Tables(File.Contents("C:\Statements\Oct.pdf"),
  [Implementation = "1.3",      // newest detection algorithm
   StartPage = 1, EndPage = 20,  // read a range of pages
   MultiPageTables = true,      // join similar tables across pages
   EnforceBorderLines = false])  // true = treat ruled lines as cell borders
```

Source: Microsoft Learn, "PDF connector" and "Pdf.Tables" function reference. The file path is an example.

3 Clean a statement in Power Query

Each fix is recorded once. Next time, it runs by itself.

Problem you'll see	Fix in the Power Query Editor
Headers are in the first data row	`Home → Use First Row as Headers`
Bank's page header repeats mid-table	Filter the Date column to remove rows that contain the header text (e.g. "Date")
Opening/closing balance lines, notes, blank rows	`Home → Remove Rows → Remove Blank Rows`, then filter out the summary lines
Narration wraps onto 2–3 lines	Microsoft's guidance: use **Fill Down** to copy the date/amount onto continuation rows, then **Group By** to combine them (Table.FillDown / Table.Group)
Dates come out wrong (DD/MM read as MM/DD)	Right-click the column → `Change Type → Using Locale…` → Date, locale **English (India)**
Amounts are text, with commas	Change Type → Decimal Number (use Using Locale → English (India) if needed)
One amount column with "Dr" / "Cr"	`Add Column → Conditional Column`: Debit when it ends with Dr, Credit when Cr; then remove the letters

Reuse it every month

Option A · same file name
Save next month's statement over the old file (same name, same folder), then `Data → Refresh All`. The import is repeatable and refreshable.

Option B · a folder of statements
Microsoft recommends the **Folder** connector for many PDFs: `Data → Get Data → From File → From Folder` → Combine. Drop each new PDF in the folder and Refresh All.

WILL BREAK IF...

the bank changes its statement layout, adds columns, or you switch banks. Each bank and each layout needs its own query. Always run the checks on the next page.

Sources: Microsoft Learn, "PDF connector" (multi-line rows, Folder connector); Office Watch, 24 Jan 2026 (repeatable and refreshable).

4 Password-protected PDFs and the 3 checks

Never trust a converted statement until the numbers reconcile.

Password-protected statement

Excel's PDF import doesn't support password-protected PDFs. For your **own** statement, open it with the password in your browser and use **Print → Save as PDF** to save an unlocked copy, then import that copy. If the PDF's security settings block printing, this won't work; download a fresh statement or ask the bank for another format. Delete the unlocked copy when you're done.

The 3 checks (run every time)

Check	How, in Excel	Pass when
1 · Row count	Count transactions on the first and last page of the PDF; compare with `=ROWS(Table1)`	Same number of rows
2 · Totals	`=SUM(Table1[Debit])` and `=SUM(Table1[Credit])` against the statement's own summary, if it has one	Both match exactly
3 · Running balance	In a helper column, row 3 onward: `=ROUND(G2+F3-E3-G3,2)` (G = Balance, F = Credit, E = Debit)	Every row shows 0. Any other value marks a missed, duplicated or misread line

Why check 3 matters most: a statement's balance column is a built-in checksum. If opening balance + credits − debits ≠ the next balance, a row was dropped, split or misread. This catches errors from every method in this ebook, including AI.

Password limitation: Office Watch, 24 Jan 2026. The checks are standard Excel formulas; adjust the column letters to your sheet.

5 Scanned PDFs: three routes

Power Query can't read images. These can, with trade-offs.

Route	How	Where it runs	Best for
A · Excel Data from Picture	`Data → From Picture → Picture From File` (or From Clipboard after `Win` + `Shift` + `S`). Review, fix, **Insert Data**.	A Microsoft 365 "connected experience": the image is shared with Microsoft's cloud to process it	One page or one table at a time
B · Windows OCR, then Excel	Snipping Tool **Text actions** or PowerToys Text Extractor (see our *Copy Text from Anything* ebook), paste, then Text to Columns	**On your PC** (Microsoft says Snipping Tool text recognition is local)	Short sections; text, not tables
C · An AI assistant	Upload the PDF to Claude, ChatGPT or Gemini and ask for a table or an Excel file	The AI company's cloud	Messy layouts, if privacy allows (pages 8–9)

Data from Picture: the verified details

- ✔ Excel for Microsoft 365; on Windows it needs Windows 11 or Windows 10 version 1903 or later, plus Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime.
- ✔ Input: an image file on your computer, or a screenshot on the clipboard.
- ✔ For best results: crop to just the table, shoot head-on, in focus.
- ✔ Supported character sets include English (Hindi is not in Microsoft's list).
- ✔ Always review the result before clicking **Insert Data**, then run the 3 checks.

Sources: Microsoft Support, "Insert data from picture"; Microsoft Learn, "Connected experiences and your content" (Appendix lists Insert data from picture); Microsoft Support, Snipping Tool ("All text recognition processes are performed locally on your device").

6 Using AI for statements: the real limits

Claude as the example — check the equivalent limits for any AI you use.

Limit (Claude, official help pages)	Value
File size in a chat	500 MB per file; up to 20 files per chat
PDF length	Up to 1,000 pages. **100 pages or fewer:** text and visuals analysed. **101–1,000 pages: text only**
Files in a Project	30 MB per file; text extraction only, except multimodal PDFs
Creating Excel/Word/PowerPoint/PDF files	Free, Pro and Max (on by default): `Settings → Capabilities → Code execution and file creation`. 30 MB per file in that environment; it uses more of your usage limit than a normal chat

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR A LONG SCANNED STATEMENT

Pages beyond 100 are read as text only, and a scanned page has no text. So a scanned statement longer than 100 pages can't be fully read in one upload. Split it into parts of 100 pages or fewer, and reconcile each part.

If you use AI, do it this way

1. Prefer the **text PDF** from net banking over a scan.
2. Ask for fixed columns: *Date | Narration | Debit | Credit | Balance*. No summaries, no guessing.
3. Ask it to flag any line it couldn't read instead of inventing a value.
4. Run the **running-balance check** (page 6) on the result.

READY-TO-USE PROMPT

```
Extract every transaction from this statement into an Excel file with
columns: Date (DD-MM-YYYY) | Narration | Debit | Credit | Balance.
Keep the original order. Copy amounts exactly; do not round or guess.
If a value is unreadable, leave it blank and list the page and line in a
sheet called 'Check'. Add a column that tests
previous balance + credit - debit = balance for every row.
```

Sources: Claude Help Center, "Upload files to Claude" and "Create and edit files with Claude".

7 Privacy before you upload a statement

A bank statement is a diary of your life. Decide where it goes.

A statement shows your account number, balances, salary credits, who you pay and where you shop. Local methods keep it on your PC. AI assistants process it on the company's servers.

Method	Where your file goes	Source
Excel Power Query (From PDF)	**Stays on your PC**	Opened from your computer in Excel for Windows
Snipping Tool Text actions	**Stays on your PC**	Microsoft: recognition is performed locally
PowerToys Text Extractor / Image to text	**Stays on your PC**	Microsoft: Windows OCR; Advanced Paste non-AI actions run locally
Excel Data from Picture	Microsoft cloud	Microsoft: a connected experience
Claude / ChatGPT / Gemini	The AI company's cloud	Each company's privacy policy

If you use an AI assistant (Claude example)

- ✔ Claude Free, Pro and Max users choose whether chats are used for training. If allowed, data is kept for **5 years**; if not, **30 days** (Anthropic, 28 Aug 2025).
- ✔ Deleted conversations aren't used for future training (Anthropic).
- ✔ Check the same settings in any AI you use (see our *Hidden AI Settings* ebook).

India's DPDP Act: what's verified

- ✔ The Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 were notified on **14 November 2025**, with an **18-month** period for phased compliance (PIB).
- ✔ The Act does **not** apply to "personal data processed by an individual for any personal or domestic purpose" — Section 3(c)(i). Your own statement, for your own use, falls here.
- ✔ Handling **other people's** data at work (customers', employees', vendors') is different. Organisations must keep reasonable security safeguards; the Act allows penalties of up to **₹250 crore** for failing to (PIB).

OUR ADVICE (NOT LEGAL ADVICE)

For anyone else's statement or data, use a local method, or get permission and follow your organisation's policy before uploading it to any AI tool.

Sources: PIB, DPDP Rules 2025 explainer (17 Nov 2025); DPDP Act 2023, Section 3; Anthropic, "Updates to Consumer Terms and Privacy Policy", 28 Aug 2025; Microsoft Support and Learn pages cited earlier.

One-page cheat sheet

Your PDF	Use	Stays on PC?
Excel/CSV download available	Download it — no conversion	Yes
Text PDF, Windows, M365/2024	Data → Get Data → From PDF, then the 3 checks	Yes
Text PDF on a Mac	Copy-paste the text, or Data from Picture	Copy-paste: yes
Password-protected	Unlocked copy via Print → Save as PDF (own files), then From PDF	Yes
Scanned, a few pages	Data from Picture, or Snipping Tool / PowerToys OCR	OCR: yes; Picture: no
Scanned, long or messy	An AI assistant, in parts of ≤100 pages, then the 3 checks	No
Someone else's statement	Local methods, or permission + your organisation's policy	Prefer yes

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Also free: *Copy Text from Anything on Your Screen · 10 Hidden AI Mistakes · Hidden AI Settings · Let AI Do Your Browser Work*

Sources (checked 12 Nov 2026)

Topic	Source
Power Query PDF	Microsoft Learn, "PDF connector" and "Pdf.Tables" reference
Versions, password, refresh	Office Watch, "How to import PDFs into Excel and auto-refresh data using Power Query", 24 Jan 2026
Mac, scanned PDFs	Microsoft Q&A threads 5396350 (Feb 2025) and 5788673 (accepted answer, 25 Feb 2026)
Data from Picture	Microsoft Support, "Insert data from picture"; Microsoft Learn, "Connected experiences and your content"
Snipping Tool OCR	Microsoft Support, "Use Snipping Tool to capture screenshots"
Claude limits	Claude Help Center, "Upload files to Claude"; "Create and edit files with Claude"
Claude data use	Anthropic, "Updates to Consumer Terms and Privacy Policy", 28 Aug 2025
DPDP	PIB explainer on DPDP Rules 2025 (Nov 2025); DPDP Act 2023, Section 3
UPI volume	NPCI data via Free Press Journal, 2 Nov 2026

Share freely with credit. Menus and limits change; check your own version. General information, not legal or financial advice.